

Probability

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Lecture 1 – 23/01/26

§1 Fundamentals

Definition 1.1. Let Ω be a set and $\mathcal{F}$ is a collection of subsets of Ω . We call $\mathcal{F}$ a *σ -algebra* if

- $\Omega \in \mathcal{F}$;
- if $A \in \mathcal{F}$, then $A^c \in \mathcal{F}$;

- if $(A_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ is a countable collection of sets in $\mathcal{F}$, then

$$\bigcup A_n \in \mathcal{F}$$

Definition 1.2. Let $\mathcal{F}$ be a σ -algebra on Ω . A function

$$\mathbb{P} : \mathcal{F} \rightarrow [0, 1]$$

is called a *probability measure* if

- $\mathbb{P}(\Omega) = 1$;
- for any countable disjoint collection $(A_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ in $\mathcal{F}$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_n\right) = \sum \mathbb{P}(A_n)$$

We call $\mathbb{P}(A)$ the *probability* of A .

Then $(\Omega, \mathcal{F}, \mathbb{P})$ is a *probability space*.

Definition 1.3. The elements of Ω are called *outcomes*, and the elements of the σ -algebra $\mathcal{F}$ are called *events*.

Importantly, we talk about probabilities of *events*, never probabilities of outcomes – the domain of $\mathbb{P}$ is $\mathcal{F}$, not Ω .

Remark. When Ω is countable, we take $\mathcal{F}$ to be all subsets of Ω . However, this framework will become useful when considering uncountable Ω .

Let us note some important properties of probability measures that follow from the definition.

- $\mathbb{P}(A^c) = 1 - \mathbb{P}(A)$;
- $\mathbb{P}(\emptyset) = 0$;
- $\mathbb{P}(A) \leq \mathbb{P}(B)$ if $A \subseteq B$;
- $\mathbb{P}(A \cup B) = \mathbb{P}(A) + \mathbb{P}(B) - \mathbb{P}(A \cap B)$.

Example 1.4 • *Rolling a fair die.* Then $\Omega = \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$, $\mathcal{F} = \mathcal{P}(\Omega)$, and

$$\mathbb{P}(A) = \frac{|A|}{6}$$

since all outcomes are equally likely.

- $\Omega = \{\omega_1, \dots, \omega_n\}$, $\mathcal{F} = \mathcal{P}(\Omega)$, $\mathbb{P}(A) = \frac{|A|}{|\Omega|}$ models the experiment of picking an element of Ω uniformly at random.
- *Picking balls from a bag.* Suppose we have n balls labelled $\{1, \dots, n\}$, and we pick $k \leq n$ balls uniformly at random without replacement. Then $\Omega = \{A : A \subseteq \{1, \dots, n\}, |A| = k\}$, so $|\Omega| = \binom{n}{k}$ and $\mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) = \binom{n}{k}^{-1}$ for any $\omega \in \Omega$.

- *A deck of 52 cards.* Take a well-shuffled deck of 52 cards. Then $\Omega = \{\text{all permutations of 52 cards}\}$, so $|\Omega| = 52!$.

What is, for example, $\mathbb{P}(\text{top 2 cards are aces})$? It is $\frac{4 \cdot 3 \cdot 50!}{52!}$.

- *Largest digit.* Consider a string of n random digits from 0 up to 9. Then $\Omega = \{0, \dots, 9\}^n$, $|\Omega| = 10^n$.

Consider the events $A_k = \{\text{no digit exceeds } k\}$, $B_k = \{\text{largest digit is } k\}$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(A_k) &= \frac{(k+1)^n}{10^n} \\ \implies \mathbb{P}(B_k) &= \mathbb{P}(A_k \setminus A_{k-1}) = \frac{(k+1)^n - k^n}{10^n} \end{aligned}$$

- *Birthday problem.* There are n people. What is the probability that at least 2 of them share the same birthday?

Assume each birthday is equally likely to be one of $\{1, \dots, 365\}$. Then $\Omega = \{1, \dots, 365\}^n$, $|\Omega| = 365^n$, and $\mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) = \frac{1}{365^n}$.

Let $A = \{\text{at least 2 people have the same birthday}\}$. Instead we count $A^c = \{\text{all birthdays different}\}$.

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(A^c) &= \frac{365 \cdot 364 \cdots (365 - n + 1)}{365^n} \\ \implies \mathbb{P}(A) &= 1 - \frac{365 \cdot 364 \cdots (365 - n + 1)}{365^n} \end{aligned}$$

Perhaps surprisingly, if $n = 22$, $\mathbb{P}(A) = 0.476$, while if $n = 23$, $\mathbb{P}(A) = 0.507$.

§1.1 Combinatorial analysis

Let us introduce some notions.

1. Let Ω be a finite set with $|\Omega| = n$. We want to partition Ω into k disjoint subsets $\Omega_1, \dots, \Omega_k$ with $|\Omega_i| = n_i$ and $\sum n_i = n$. How many ways are there to do this? It is

$$\begin{aligned}
 M &= \binom{n}{n_1} \cdot \binom{n-n_1}{n_2} \cdots \binom{n-(n_1+\cdots+n_{k-1})}{n_k} \\
 &= \frac{n!}{n_1!n_2!\cdots n_k!} \\
 &= \binom{n}{n_1, n_2, \dots, n_k}
 \end{aligned}$$

This is the *multinomial coefficient*.

2. Suppose $f : \{1, \dots, k\} \rightarrow \{1, \dots, n\}$ (with $k \leq n$). f is *strictly increasing* if $x < y \implies f(x) < f(y)$, and f is *increasing* if $x < y \implies f(x) \leq f(y)$.

How many strictly increasing $f : \{1, \dots, k\} \rightarrow \{1, \dots, n\}$ are there? Such a function is determined uniquely by its range, so there are $\binom{n}{k}$ of them.

What about increasing functions? Let's define a bijection

$$\{f : \{1, \dots, k\} \rightarrow \{1, \dots, n\} \text{ inc.}\} \rightarrow \{f : \{1, \dots, k\} \rightarrow \{1, n+k-1\} \text{ strictly inc.}\}$$

which takes f to g with $g(i) = f(i) + i - 1$. Hence we have $\binom{n+k-1}{k}$ such functions.

Definition 1.5 (Asymptotic notation). If (a_n) and (b_n) are sequences, we write $a_n \sim b_n$ if

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{a_n}{b_n} = 1$$

§1.2 Stirling's formula

Theorem 1.6 (Stirling)

$$n! \sim n^n \sqrt{2\pi n} e^{-n}$$

as $n \rightarrow \infty$.

Weaker statement. We shall first show a weaker statement, that $\log n! \sim n \log n$.

Define $l_n = \log n! = \log 2 + \cdots + \log n$. We have

$$\log \lfloor x \rfloor \leq \log x \leq \log \lceil x \rceil$$

Integrating from 1 to n gives

$$\begin{aligned}
 \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} \log k &\leq \int_1^n \log x \, dx \leq \sum_{k=1}^n \log k \\
 \implies l_{n-1} &\leq n \log n - n + 1 \leq l_n \\
 \implies n \log n - n + 1 &\leq l_n \leq (n+1) \log(n+1) - (n+1) + 1
 \end{aligned}$$

Now the result follows by dividing through by $n \log n$ and taking the limit. ■

Non-examinable proof of Stirling. For every twice-differentiable $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, for all $a < b$, we have

$$\int_a^b f(x) dx = \frac{f(a) + f(b)}{2}(b - a) - \frac{1}{2} \int_a^b (x - a)(b - x) f''(x) dx$$

obtained by integrating twice by parts. Put $f = \log$, $a = k$, $b = k + 1$ for $k \in \mathbb{N}$, to get

$$\int_k^{k+1} \log x dx = \frac{\log k + \log(k + 1)}{2} + \frac{1}{2} \int_k^{k+1} \frac{(x - k)(k + 1 - x)}{x^2} dx$$

Summing from $k = 1$ to $n - 1$, we have

$$\int_1^n \log x dx = \frac{\log(n - 1)! + \log n!}{2} + \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} a_k$$

where $a_k = \frac{1}{2} \int_0^1 \frac{x(1-x)}{(x+k)^2} dx$. Hence

$$n \log n - n + 1 = \log n! - \frac{\log n}{2} + \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} a_k$$

and so

$$\begin{aligned} \log n! &= n \log n - n + 1 + \frac{\log n}{2} - \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} a_k \\ \implies n! &= n^n \cdot e^{-n} \cdot \sqrt{n} \cdot \exp \left(1 - \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} a_k \right) \end{aligned}$$

Let us now consider

$$\begin{aligned} a_k &= \frac{1}{2} \int_0^1 \frac{x(1-x)}{(x+k)^2} dx \\ &\leq \frac{1}{2} \int_0^1 \frac{1}{2k^2} \int_0^1 x(1-x) dx \\ &= \frac{1}{12k^2} \end{aligned}$$

and so $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} a_k < \infty$. Now put

$$\begin{aligned} A &= \exp \left(1 - \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} a_k \right) \\ \implies n! &= n^n \cdot e^{-n} \cdot \sqrt{n} \cdot A \cdot \underbrace{\exp \left(\sum_{k=n}^{\infty} a_k \right)}_{\rightarrow 1 \text{ as } n \rightarrow \infty} \\ \implies \frac{n!}{n^n e^{-n} \sqrt{n}} &\rightarrow A \text{ as } n \rightarrow \infty \end{aligned}$$

It remains to show that $A = \sqrt{2\pi}$. Consider

$$2^{-2n} \binom{2n}{n} = 2^{-2n} \frac{(2n)!}{(n!)^2}$$

$$\begin{aligned} &\sim \frac{2^{-2n}(2n)^{2n}e^{-2n}\sqrt{2n}A}{n^{2n}e^{-2n}nA^2} \\ &= \frac{\sqrt{2}}{A\sqrt{n}} \end{aligned}$$

Now, we shall use a different method to show

$$2^{-2n} \binom{2n}{n} \sim \frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi n}} \text{ as } n \rightarrow \infty$$

Consider

$$I_n = \int_0^{\pi/2} \cos^n \theta \, d\theta$$

We have $I_0 = \frac{\pi}{2}$, $I_1 = 1$, and, by integrating by parts, we have

$$I_n = \frac{n-1}{n} I_{n-2} \quad (*)$$

so that

$$\begin{aligned} I_{2n} &= \frac{2n-1}{2n} I_{2n-2} \\ &= \dots = \frac{(2n-1)(2n-3)\dots 3 \cdot 1}{(2n)(2n-2)\dots 2} \cdot \frac{\pi}{2} \\ &= \frac{2n(2n-1)(2n-2)\dots 3 \cdot 2 \cdot 1}{2n \cdot 2n \cdot (2n-2) \cdot (2n-2) \dots 2 \cdot 2} \cdot \frac{\pi}{2} \\ &= \frac{(2n)!}{2^{2n}(n!)^2} \cdot \frac{\pi}{2} \\ &= \frac{\pi}{2} \cdot 2^{-2n} \binom{2n}{n} \end{aligned}$$

and we can similarly obtain

$$\begin{aligned} I_{2n+1} &= \frac{2n \dots 4 \cdot 2}{(2n+1) \dots 3 \cdot 1} \cdot 1 \\ &= \frac{1}{2n+1} \left(2^{-2n} \binom{2n}{n} \right)^{-1} \end{aligned}$$

Now, we want to show that $\frac{I_{2n}}{I_{2n+1}} \rightarrow 1$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$. By (*), we have

$$\frac{I_n}{I_{n-2}} \rightarrow 1 \text{ as } n \rightarrow \infty$$

But $I_n = \int_0^{\pi/2} \cos^n \theta \, d\theta$, so I_n is decreasing in n . This gives

$$\frac{I_{2n}}{I_{2n-2}} \leq \frac{I_{2n}}{I_{2n+1}} \leq \frac{I_{2n-1}}{I_{2n+1}}$$

which shows the result by sandwich. Hence, we get, as $n \rightarrow \infty$,

$$\begin{aligned} &\frac{\frac{\pi}{2} \cdot 2^{-2n} \cdot \binom{2n}{n}}{\frac{1}{2n+1} \cdot \left(2^{-2n} \binom{2n}{n} \right)^{-1}} \rightarrow 1 \\ \implies &\left(2^{-2n} \binom{2n}{n} \right)^2 \sim \frac{1}{\pi n} \end{aligned}$$

■

Proposition 1.7 (Countable subadditivity)

Let (A_n) be a collection of events in $\mathcal{F}$. Then

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_n\right) \leq \sum \mathbb{P}(A_n)$$

Proof. Let $B_1 = A_1$, and for $n \geq 2$, let $B_n = A_n \setminus (A_1 \cup \cdots \cup A_{n-1})$. By definition, it's immediate that (B_n) is a disjoint collection of sets in $\mathcal{F}$, and $\bigcup B_n = \bigcup A_n$, so

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_n\right) &= \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup B_n\right) = \sum \mathbb{P}(B_n) \\ &\leq \sum \mathbb{P}(A_n) \end{aligned}$$

since $B_n \subseteq A_n$ for all n . ■

Proposition 1.8 (Continuity of probability measures)

Take a sequence of events $(A_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ such that $A_n \subseteq A_{n+1}$ for all n – we say (A_n) is an *increasing* sequence.

Then $\mathbb{P}(A_n)$ is increasing and converges. In particular,

$$\mathbb{P}(A_n) \rightarrow \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_n\right)$$

as $n \rightarrow \infty$.

Proof. Define $B_1 = A_1$, and for $n \geq 2$, let $B_n = A_n \setminus (A_1 \cup \cdots \cup A_{n-1})$. Then

$$\bigcup_{k=1}^n B_k = A_n$$

and the B_n 's are disjoint. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(A_n) &= \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{k=1}^n B_k\right) \\ &= \sum_{k=1}^n \mathbb{P}(B_k) \rightarrow \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(B_k) \end{aligned}$$

Also,

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(B_k) &= \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup B_k\right) \\ &= \mathbb{P}(A_k) \end{aligned}$$

■

Corollary 1.9

Analogously, take a sequence of events (A_n) such that $A_{n+1} \subseteq A_n$ for all n – we say (A_n) is a decreasing sequence. Then

$$\mathbb{P}(A_n) \rightarrow \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcap A_n\right)$$

Proof. Take complements and use the previous claim. ■

Proposition 1.10 (Inclusion-exclusion formula for probability measures)

Let $A_1, \dots, A_n \in \mathcal{F}$. Then

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_i\right) = \sum_{k=1}^n (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n} \mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k})$$

Proof. We proceed by induction.

Base case. ADD

Inductive step. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^n A_i\right) &= \mathbb{P}\left(\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} A_i\right) \cup A_n\right) \\ &= \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} A_i\right) + \mathbb{P}(A_n) - \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} A_i \cap A_n\right) \\ &= \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} A_i\right) + \mathbb{P}(A_n) - \mathbb{P}\left(\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} A_i\right) \cap A_n\right) \\ &= \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} A_i\right) + \mathbb{P}(A_n) - \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} \underbrace{(A_i \cap A_n)}_{B_i}\right) \end{aligned}$$

Applying the inductive hypothesis, we get

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} A_i\right) &= \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n-1} \mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k}) \\ \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} B_i\right) &= \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n-1} \mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k} \cap A_n) \end{aligned}$$

and subbing this in, we will find that everything works out. ■

Proposition 1.11 (Bonferroni inequalities)

Let $A_1, \dots, A_n$ be events. Then

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_i\right) \begin{cases} \leq \sum_{k=1}^r (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n} \mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k}) & \text{if } r \text{ odd} \\ \geq \sum_{k=1}^r (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n} \mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k}) & \text{if } r \text{ even} \end{cases}$$

where those sums are just truncated expansions of inclusion-exclusion.

Proof. We induct again.

Base case. $\mathbb{P}(A \cup B) = \mathbb{P}(A) + \mathbb{P}(B) - \mathbb{P}(A \cap B) \leq \mathbb{P}(A) + \mathbb{P}(B)$

Inductive step. Suppose r is odd. Then

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^n A_i\right) = \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} A_i\right) + \mathbb{P}(A_n) - \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} \underbrace{(A_i \cap A_n)}_{B_i}\right)$$

By the inductive hypotheses,

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} A_i\right) &\leq \sum_{k=1}^r (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n-1} \mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k}) \\ \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_{i=1}^{n-1} (A_i \cap A_n)\right) &\geq \sum_{k=1}^{r-1} (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n-1} \mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k} \cap A_n) \end{aligned}$$

where in the former, we choose to apply the identity for odd r , and in the latter, we apply it for even $r-1$. Substituting much as for the proof of the inclusion-exclusion formula, we obtain the result. The even case is analogous. ■

Let us now consider the special case where Ω is a finite set and $\mathbb{P}(A) = |A| / |\Omega|$. Then we have

Corollary 1.12 (Inclusion-exclusion principle for sets)

Suppose Ω is finite. Then

$$|A_1 \cup \dots \cup A_n| = \sum_{k=1}^n (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n} |A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k}|$$

Proof. Consider the probability space $(\Omega, \mathcal{F}, \mathbb{P})$ where $\mathbb{P}(A) = |A| / |\Omega|$. Then, apply inclusion-exclusion and cancel $1/|\Omega|$ from both sides. ■

§2 Basic applications

§2.1 Counting surjections

Define a probability space as follows:

$$\Omega = \{f : \{1, \dots, n\} \rightarrow \{1, \dots, m\}\}$$

$$A = \{f \in \Omega : f \text{ is a surjection}\}$$

What is $|A|$? Let us define a set of events

$$A_i = \{f \in \Omega : i \notin \{f(1), \dots, f(n)\}\}, i \in \{1, \dots, m\}$$

so that

$$\begin{aligned} A &= A_1^c \cap \dots \cap A_m^c = (A_1 \cup \dots \cup A_m)^c \\ \Rightarrow |A| &= |\Omega| - |A_1 \cup \dots \cup A_m| \\ &= |\Omega| - \sum_{k=1}^m (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq m} |A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k}| \\ &= \underbrace{|\Omega|}_{m^n} - \sum_{k=1}^m (-1)^{k+1} \binom{m}{k} (m-k)^n \\ &= \sum_{k=0}^m (-1)^k \binom{m}{k} (m-k)^n \end{aligned}$$

Lecture 4 – 30/01/26

§2.2 Counting derangements

Definition 2.1. A *derangement* is a permutation with no fixed points.

Let

$$\begin{aligned} \Omega &= \{\text{permutations of } \{1, \dots, n\}\} \\ A &= \{\text{derangements}\} \end{aligned}$$

Let

$$A_i = \{f \in \Omega : f(i) = i\}$$

so that

$$\begin{aligned} A &= A_1^c \cap \dots \cap A_n^c = (A_1 \cup \dots \cup A_n)^c \\ \Rightarrow \mathbb{P}(A) &= 1 - \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_i\right) = 1 - \sum_{k=1}^n (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n} \underbrace{\mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k})}_{\frac{(n-k)!}{n!}} \\ &= 1 - \sum_{k=1}^n (-1)^{k+1} \binom{n}{k} \frac{(n-k)!}{n!} \\ &= 1 - \sum_{k=1}^n (-1)^{k+1} \frac{1}{k!} \\ &= \sum_{k=0}^n \frac{(-1)^k}{k!} \rightarrow e^{-1} \end{aligned}$$

§3 Independence and conditional probability

Definition 3.1 (Independence). Let $A, B \in \mathcal{F}$. We say A and B are *independent* and write $A \perp B$ if

$$\mathbb{P}(A \cap B) = \mathbb{P}(A)\mathbb{P}(B)$$

Likewise, a countable collection of events $(A_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ is said to be independent if, for distinct $i_1, \dots, i_k$,

$$\mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k}) = \prod_{j=1}^k \mathbb{P}(A_{i_j})$$

Remark. Pairwise independence of events does not imply independence.

Example

Toss a fair coin twice. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \Omega &= \{(0, 0), (0, 1), (1, 0), (1, 1)\} \\ \mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) &= \frac{1}{4} \end{aligned}$$

Let

$$\begin{aligned} A &= \{(0, 0), (0, 1)\} \\ B &= \{(0, 0), (1, 0)\} \\ C &= \{(1, 0), (0, 1)\} \end{aligned}$$

We have $\mathbb{P}(A) = \mathbb{P}(B) = \mathbb{P}(C)$, and furthermore we can check that $A \perp B$, $A \perp C$ and $B \perp C$. But $\mathbb{P}(A \cap B \cap C) = \mathbb{P}(\emptyset) = 0$, so they are not independent.

Proposition 3.2

If A is independent of B , then A is independent of B^c .

Proof. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(A \cap B^c) &= \mathbb{P}(A) - \mathbb{P}(A \cap B) \\ &= \mathbb{P}(A)(1 - \mathbb{P}(B)) \\ &= \mathbb{P}(A)\mathbb{P}(B^c) \end{aligned}$$

■

Definition 3.3 (Conditional probability). Take a probability space $(\Omega, \mathcal{F}, \mathbb{P})$ and $B \in \mathcal{F}$ with $\mathbb{P}(B) > 0$. For $A \in \mathcal{F}$ we write the *conditional probability of A given B*

$$\mathbb{P}(A \mid B) = \frac{\mathbb{P}(A \cap B)}{\mathbb{P}(B)}$$

Remark. Notably, if $A \perp B$, then $\mathbb{P}(A | B) = \mathbb{P}(A)$, as we would expect.

Proposition 3.4 (Countable additivity for conditional probability)

Suppose $(A_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ is a disjoint sequence in $\mathcal{F}$. Then

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_n \mid B\right) = \sum \mathbb{P}(A_n \mid B)$$

Proof. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_n \mid B\right) &= \frac{\mathbb{P}(\bigcup A_n \cap B)}{\mathbb{P}(B)} \\ &= \frac{\mathbb{P}(\bigcup (A_n \cap B))}{\mathbb{P}(B)} \\ &= \sum \frac{\mathbb{P}(A_n \cap B)}{\mathbb{P}(B)} \\ &= \sum \mathbb{P}(A_n \mid B) \end{aligned}$$

■

Proposition 3.5 (Law of total probability)

Suppose $(B_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ is a disjoint collection in $\mathcal{F}$, $\bigcup B_n = \Omega$, and $\mathbb{P}(B_n) > 0$ for every n . Let $A \in \mathcal{F}$, then

$$\mathbb{P}(A) = \sum_n \mathbb{P}(A \mid B_n) \mathbb{P}(B_n)$$

Proof. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(A) &= \mathbb{P}\left(A \cap \left(\bigcup B_n\right)\right) \\ &= \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup (B_n \cap A)\right) \\ &= \sum \mathbb{P}(B_n \cap A) \\ &= \sum \mathbb{P}(A \mid B_n) \mathbb{P}(B_n) \end{aligned}$$

■

Proposition 3.6 (Bayes' theorem)

Suppose (B_n) are disjoint, $\bigcup B_n = \Omega$ and $\mathbb{P}(B_n) > 0$ for every n . Let $A \in \mathcal{F}$, then

$$\mathbb{P}(B_n \mid A) = \frac{\mathbb{P}(A \mid B_n) \cdot \mathbb{P}(B_n)}{\sum_k \mathbb{P}(A \mid B_k) \mathbb{P}(B_k)}$$

Proof sketch. Use the definitions of $\mathbb{P}(B_n \mid A)$ and $\mathbb{P}(A \mid B_n)$, and expand the bottom using the law of total probability. ■

This formula is the basis of so-called Bayesian statistics. We know the probability of $\mathbb{P}(B_n)$ and we have a model which gives us $\mathbb{P}(A \mid B_n)$. With the formula, we find the *posterior* probability of B_n given that A occurred.

Example (False positives for a rare condition)

Suppose that condition A affects 0.1% of the population. We have a medical test which is positive for 98% of the affected population and 1% of the unaffected population. What is the probability that a random individual who tests positive has the disease?

Put $A = \{\text{individual suffers from } A\}$, $P = \{\text{individual tests positive}\}$. We have $\mathbb{P}(A) = 0.001$, $\mathbb{P}(P \mid A) = 0.98$, $\mathbb{P}(P \mid A^c) = 0.01$, so

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}(A \mid P) &= \frac{\mathbb{P}(P \mid A)\mathbb{P}(A)}{\mathbb{P}(P \mid A)\mathbb{P}(A) + \mathbb{P}(P \mid A^c)\mathbb{P}(A^c)} \\ &= 0.089\end{aligned}$$

In particular, we can see

$$\mathbb{P}(A \mid P) = \frac{1}{1 + \frac{\mathbb{P}(P \mid A^c)\mathbb{P}(A^c)}{\mathbb{P}(P \mid A)\mathbb{P}(A)}}$$

Since $\mathbb{P}(A^c)$ and $\mathbb{P}(P \mid A)$ are both very close to one, the relevant ratio is

$$\frac{\mathbb{P}(P \mid A^c)}{\mathbb{P}(A)}$$

But since $\mathbb{P}(P \mid A^c) \gg \mathbb{P}(A)$, this causes a very small value for $\mathbb{P}(A \mid P)$.

Example • What is the probability that I have two boys given that I have two children one of whom is a boy?

Since no further information is given, we take all outcomes to be equally likely. Let

$$BG = \{\text{elder child a boy, younger a girl}\}$$

with GB, BB, GG defined analogously. Then we want

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}(BB \mid BB \cup BG \cup GB) &= \frac{\mathbb{P}(BB)}{\mathbb{P}(BB \cup BG \cup GB)} \\ &= \frac{\frac{1}{4}}{\frac{3}{4}} = \frac{1}{3}\end{aligned}$$

- What about $\mathbb{P}(\text{both boys} \mid \text{eldest a boy})$? This is

$$\mathbb{P}(BB \mid BB \cup BG) = \frac{1}{2}$$

- What about $\mathbb{P}(\text{both boys} \mid \text{one a boy born on a Thursday})$? Denote a boy born on Thursday by T, a boy not born on Thursday by N, and a girl by G. Then we want

$$\begin{aligned}&\mathbb{P}(TT \cup TN \cup NT \mid TT \cup TG \cup GT \cup TN \cup NT) \\ &= \frac{\mathbb{P}(TT \cup TN \cup NT)}{\mathbb{P}(TT \cup TG \cup GT \cup TN \cup NT)} \\ &= \frac{\left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{7}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{7}\right) \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{6}{7}\right) + \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{6}{7}\right) \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{7}\right)}{\left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{7}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{7}\right) \cdot \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2} \cdot \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{7}\right) + \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{7}\right) \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{6}{7}\right) + \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{6}{7}\right) \left(\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{7}\right)} \\ &=; \frac{13}{27}\end{aligned}$$

Morally speaking, we're providing information that helps specify the boy in question more, which brings the probability closer to a half.

Example (Simpson's paradox)

Consider the following data:

<i>All applicants</i>	Admitted	Rejected	% Admitted
State	25	25	50%
Indep.	28	22	56%

<i>London schools</i>	Admitted	Rejected	% Admitted
State	15	22	41%
Indep.	5	8	38%

<i>Cambridge schools</i>	Admitted	Rejected	% Admitted
State	10	3	77%
Indep.	23	14	62%

– paradoxically, the state admission rate is higher when the school locations are taken individually, but the independent admission right is higher for the combined data. This phenomenon is called *confounding*, and arises when we aggregate data from disparate populations.

Let

$$\begin{aligned}
 A &= \{\text{individual is admitted}\} \\
 B &= \{\text{individual from London}\} \\
 C &= \{\text{individual from state school}\}
 \end{aligned}$$

Then

$$\begin{aligned}
 \mathbb{P}(A \mid B \cap C) &> \mathbb{P}(A \mid B \cap C^c) \\
 \mathbb{P}(A \mid B^c \cap C) &> \mathbb{P}(A \mid B^c \cap C^c) \\
 \text{but } \mathbb{P}(A \mid C) &< \mathbb{P}(A \mid C^c)
 \end{aligned}$$

Let's examine how this can happen. We have

$$\begin{aligned}
 \mathbb{P}(A \mid C) &= \mathbb{P}(A \cap B \mid C) + \mathbb{P}(A \cap B^c \mid C) \\
 &= \frac{\mathbb{P}(A \cap B \cap C)}{\mathbb{P}(C)} + \frac{\mathbb{P}(A \cap B^c \cap C)}{\mathbb{P}(C)} \\
 &= \frac{\mathbb{P}(A \mid B \cap C)\mathbb{P}(B \cap C)}{\mathbb{P}(C)} + \frac{\mathbb{P}(A \mid B^c \cap C)\mathbb{P}(B^c \cap C)}{\mathbb{P}(C)} \\
 &= \mathbb{P}(A \mid B \cap C)\mathbb{P}(B \mid C) + \mathbb{P}(A \mid B^c \cap C)\mathbb{P}(B^c \mid C) \\
 &> \mathbb{P}(A \mid B \cap C^c)\mathbb{P}(B \mid C) + \mathbb{P}(A \mid B^c \cap C^c)\mathbb{P}(B^c \mid C)
 \end{aligned}$$

by the first two inequalities from above. Now, if $\mathbb{P}(B \mid C) = \mathbb{P}(B \mid C^c)$, then we would get $\mathbb{P}(A \mid C) > \mathbb{P}(A \mid C^c)$, which is the intuitive expectation – but here this does not hold, and so we can make the ‘paradox’ hold.

Even more simply, this is just the fact that, if $\frac{a_1}{a_2} > \frac{b_1}{b_2}$ and $\frac{c_1}{c_2} > \frac{d_1}{d_2}$, it does not necessarily hold that $\frac{a_1+c_1}{a_2+c_2} > \frac{b_1+d_1}{b_2+d_2}$.

§4 Probability distributions

§4.1 Discrete probability distributions

Take a probability space $(\Omega, \mathcal{F}, \mathbb{P})$ with Ω either finite or countable – that is, $\Omega = \{\omega_1, \omega_2, \dots\}$. As normal, we take $\mathcal{F} = \mathcal{P}(\Omega)$, and so we need only care about $\mathbb{P}(\{\omega_i\})$ for every i .

Definition 4.1 (Discrete probability distributions). For such a setup, we call the sequence of probabilities $(\mathbb{P}(\{\omega_i\}))_i$ a *discrete probability distribution*. We may also write $p_i = \mathbb{P}(\{\omega_i\})$.

Let us consider some examples of discrete probability distributions.

- ① *Bernoulli distribution*. The Bernoulli distribution models the outcome of a toss of a biased coin. We have $\Omega = \{0, 1\}$, $p_0 = \mathbb{P}(\{0\}) = 1 - p$, $p_1 = \mathbb{P}(\{1\}) = p$ for some p with $p \in [0, 1]$.

- ② *Binomial distribution*. We denote this $\text{Bin}(n, p)$, with $n \in \mathbb{N}$, $p \in [0, 1]$. It models the number of heads seen for n independent tosses of a p -biased coin. We have

$$\Omega = \{0, 1, \dots, n\}$$

$$p_k = \binom{n}{k} p^k (1 - p)^{n-k}$$

- ③ *Multinomial distribution*. We denote this $\text{M}(n, p_1, \dots, p_k)$, where $p_i \geq 0$, $\sum p_i = 1$. Given k boxes and n balls placed in box i with p_i , the multinomial distribution gives the probability of n_l balls in box l for every n . We have

$$\Omega = \left\{ (n_1, \dots, n_k) \in \mathbb{N}^k : \sum_{i=1}^k n_i = n \right\}$$

$$\mathbb{P}(n_1, \dots, n_k) = \binom{n}{n_1} p_1^{n_1} \cdot \binom{n - n_1}{n_2} p_2^{n_2} \cdots \binom{n - n_1 - \dots - n_{k-1}}{n_k} p_k^{n_k}$$

$$= \binom{n}{n_1, n_2, \dots, n_k} p_1^{n_1} p_2^{n_2} \cdots p_k^{n_k}$$

- ④ *Geometric distribution*. The geometric distribution gives the probability that the first heads achieved on a p -coin is after k tosses:

$$\Omega = \{1, 2, \dots\}$$

$$p_k = (1 - p)^{k-1} p$$

Alternatively, we might want to model the probability that we see k tails before the first heads:

$$\Omega = \{0, 1, \dots\}$$

$$p'_k = (1 - p)^k p$$

- ⑤ *Poisson distribution*. Suppose customers arrive into a shop in $[0, 1]$. Discretise $[0, 1]$ into $\left\{ \left[\frac{i-1}{N}, \frac{i}{N} \right] \right\}$, $i = 1, \dots, N$, $N \in \mathbb{N}$. Independently, in each interval, a customer arrives with probability p , and doesn't arrive with probability $1 - p$.

Then

$$\mathbb{P}(k \text{ customers have arrived}) = \binom{N}{k} p^k (1-p)^{N-k}$$

– in other words, this follows a binomial distribution. Now, take $p = \frac{\lambda}{N}$, so

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(k \text{ customers have arrived}) &= \frac{N!}{k!(N-k)!} \left(\frac{\lambda}{N}\right)^k \left(1 - \frac{\lambda}{N}\right)^{N-k} \\ &= \frac{\lambda^k}{k!} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{N(N-1)\dots(N-k+1)}{N^k}}_{\rightarrow 1} \underbrace{\left(1 - \frac{\lambda}{N}\right)^{N-k}}_{\rightarrow e^{-\lambda}} \\ &\rightarrow e^{-\lambda} \frac{\lambda^k}{k!} \end{aligned}$$

as $N \rightarrow \infty$. Hence we have

$$\begin{aligned} \Omega &= \{0, 1, 2, \dots\} \\ p_k &= e^{-\lambda} \frac{\lambda^k}{k!} \end{aligned}$$

and we denote this $\text{Poi}(\lambda)$.

§4.2 Random variables

Definition 4.2. Given a probability space $(\Omega, \mathcal{F}, \mathbb{P})$, a *random variable* is a function

$$X : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$$

satisfying

$$\{\omega \in \Omega : X(\omega) \leq x\} \in \mathcal{F}$$

for any x . We have the shorthand notation $\{X \leq x\}$ to refer to $\{\omega \in \Omega : X(\omega) \leq x\}$, and $\{X \in A\} = \{\omega \in \Omega : X(\omega) \in A\}$.

Definition 4.3. Let $A \in \mathcal{F}$. Define the *indicator* of A

$$1_A(\omega) = 1(\omega \in A) = \begin{cases} 1 & \omega \in A \\ 0 & \omega \notin A \end{cases}$$

Since $A \in \mathcal{F}$, 1_A is a random variable.

Definition 4.4. Suppose X is a random variable. The *probability distribution function* of X is given by

$$\begin{aligned} F_X(x) &: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow [0, 1] \\ x &\mapsto \mathbb{P}(\{\omega \in \Omega : X(\omega) \leq x\}) = \mathbb{P}(X \leq x) \end{aligned}$$

Definition 4.5. $X = (X_1, \dots, X_n)$ is called a *random variable in $\mathbb{R}^n$* if

$$(X_1, \dots, X_n) : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$$

is a function such that, for any $x_1, \dots, x_n$,

$$\{\omega : X_1(\omega) \leq x_1, \dots, X_n(\omega) \leq x_n\} \in \mathcal{F}$$

which we denote with the shorthand $\{X_1 \leq x_1, \dots, X_n \leq x_n\}$.

Note that $(X_1, \dots, X_n)$ is a random variable if and only if all of $X_1, \dots, X_n$ are.

Definition 4.6. A random variable X is called *discrete* if it takes values in some countable set S .

Definition 4.7. For a discrete random variable, we are able to write

$$p_x = \mathbb{P}(X = x) = \mathbb{P}(\omega : X(\omega) = x)$$

Then, $(p_x)_{x \in S}$ is called the *probability mass function* of X .

Now we are able to say things like

$$\text{for any } A \subseteq S, \mathbb{P}(X \in A) = \sum_{x \in A} p_x$$

If p_x follows a given distribution, then we say X is a random variable with that distribution or a random variable following that distribution.

Definition 4.8. Let $X_1, \dots, X_n$ be discrete random variables with values in $S_1, \dots, S_n$. They are called *independent* if

$$\mathbb{P}(X_1 = x_1, \dots, X_n = x_n) = \mathbb{P}(X_1 = x_1) \dots \mathbb{P}(X_n = x_n)$$

for all $x_1 \in S_1, \dots, x_n \in S_n$.

Example 4.9

Toss a p -coin N times independently. Then

$$\Omega = \{0, 1\}^N$$

and every $\omega \in \Omega$ is of the form $(\omega_1, \dots, \omega_N)$, where ω_i is the i^{th} outcome. Hence

$$p_\omega = \mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) = \prod_{k=1}^N p^{\omega_k} (1-p)^{1-\omega_k}$$

Let us also define random variables X_k for each k , satisfying $X_k(\omega) = \omega_k$. Clearly X_k is a Bernoulli r.v. of parameter p . We claim $X_1, \dots, X_N$ are independent: we have

$$\begin{aligned} P(X_1 = x_1, \dots, X_N = x_N) &= \prod_{k=1}^N p^{x_k} (1-p)^{1-x_k} \\ &= \prod_{k=1}^N \mathbb{P}(X_k = x_k) \end{aligned}$$

§4.3 Expectation

Definition 4.10. Suppose Ω is finite or countable, and let $X : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be a discrete random variable. We say X is *non-negative* if $X \geq 0$ – then we define the *expectation* of X by

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_{\omega \in \Omega} \mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) \cdot X(\omega)$$

We can equivalently let

$$\Omega_X = \{X(\omega) : \omega \in \Omega\}$$

so that

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[X] &= \sum_{\omega \in \Omega} X(\omega) \cdot \mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) \\ &= \sum_{x \in \Omega_X} \sum_{\omega \in \{X=x\}} X(\omega) \mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) \\ &= \sum_{x \in \Omega_X} \sum_{\omega \in \{X=x\}} x \mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) \\ &= \sum_{x \in \Omega_X} x \sum_{\omega \in \{X=x\}} \mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) \\ &= \sum_{x \in \Omega_X} x \cdot \mathbb{P}(X = x) \end{aligned}$$

or in other words the average of the values taken by X , weighted by their probabilities.

Example 4.11

Suppose $X \sim \text{Bin}(n, p)$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[X] &= \sum_{k=0}^N k \mathbb{P}(X = k) \\ &= \sum_{k=0}^N k \binom{N}{k} p^k (1-p)^{N-k} \\ &= \sum_{k=0}^N k \frac{N!}{(N-k)!k!} p^k (1-p)^{N-k} \\ &= \sum_{k=0}^{N-1} N \cdot \binom{N-1}{k} p^{k+1} (1-p)^{N-k-1} \cdot p \\ &= Np \cdot (p + 1 - p)^{N-1} = Np \end{aligned}$$

Example 4.12

Suppose $X \sim \text{Poi}(\lambda)$. Then

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}[X] &= \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} k \mathbb{P}(X = k) \\ &= \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} k e^{-\lambda} \frac{\lambda^k}{k!} \\ &= e^{-\lambda} \cdot \lambda \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{\lambda^{k-1}}{(k-1)!} = \lambda\end{aligned}$$

Let X be a random variable – then we define

$$\begin{aligned}X^+ &= \max(X, 0) \\ X^- &= \max(-X, 0)\end{aligned}$$

so $X = X^+ - X^-$ and $|X| = X^+ + X^-$. Supposing X is discrete, we can define the expectations of $\mathbb{E}[X^+]$ and $\mathbb{E}[X^-]$, since they are both non-negative.

If at least one of $\mathbb{E}[X^+]$ and $\mathbb{E}[X^-]$ is finite, we define

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \mathbb{E}[X^+] - \mathbb{E}[X^-]$$

If both are infinite, the expectation of X is undefined.

Also, if $\mathbb{E}[|X|]$ (which we define in the obvious way) is $< \infty$, we say X is integrable. When $\mathbb{E}[X]$ is well-defined, we have

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_{x \in \Omega_X} x \cdot \mathbb{P}(X = x)$$

We have some properties of expectations as follows:

- If $X \geq 0$, then $\mathbb{E}[X] \geq 0$.
- If $X \geq 0$ and $\mathbb{E}[X] = 0$, then $\mathbb{P}(X = 0) = 1$.
- If $c \in \mathbb{R}$, then $\mathbb{E}[cX] = c\mathbb{E}[X]$ and $\mathbb{E}[c + X] = c + \mathbb{E}[X]$.
- If X and Y are random variables (and X, Y integrable), then $\mathbb{E}[X + Y] = \mathbb{E}[X] + \mathbb{E}[Y]$.
- In the countable case, we take $c_1, \dots, c_n \in \mathbb{R}$ and $X_1, \dots, X_n$ integrable, and then we have

$$\mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{i=1}^n c_i X_i\right] = \sum_{i=1}^n c_i \mathbb{E}[X_i]$$

Let us give a proof of the final identity in the case where Ω is countable. We have

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}\left[\sum_n X_n\right] &= \sum_{\omega \in \Omega} \left(\sum_n X_n(\omega)\right) \mathbb{P}(\{\omega\}) \\ &= \sum_n \sum_{\omega \in \Omega} X_n(\omega) \mathbb{P}(\{\omega\})\end{aligned}$$

$$= \sum_n \mathbb{E}[X_n]$$

where we can interchange sums by the assumption that the random variables are integrable.

We also have the useful result that, if $X = 1(A)$ for some event A ,

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \mathbb{P}(A)$$

Proposition 4.13

Let $g : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, and define the random variable $g(X)$ by

$$g(X)(\omega) = g(X(\omega))$$

Then

$$\mathbb{E}[g(X)] = \sum_{x \in \Omega_X} g(x) \mathbb{P}(X = x)$$

Proof. Put $Y = g(X)$, then

$$\begin{aligned} \{Y = y\} &= \{\omega : Y(\omega) = y\} \\ &= \{\omega : g(X(\omega)) = y\} \\ &= \{\omega : X(\omega) \in g^{-1}(\{y\})\} \\ &= \{X \in g^{-1}(\{y\})\} \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[Y] &= \sum_{y \in \Omega_Y} y \cdot \mathbb{P}(Y = y) \\ &= \sum_{y \in \Omega_Y} y \cdot \mathbb{P}(X \in g^{-1}(\{y\})) \\ &= \sum_{y \in \Omega_Y} y \sum_{x \in g^{-1}(\{y\})} \mathbb{P}(X = x) \\ &= \sum_{y \in \Omega_Y} \sum_{x \in g^{-1}(\{y\})} g(x) \mathbb{P}(X = x) \\ &= \sum_{x \in \Omega_X} g(x) \cdot \mathbb{P}(X = x) \end{aligned}$$

■

Proposition 4.14

Suppose that $X \geq 0$ and takes integer values. Then

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(X \geq k) = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(X > k)$$

Proof. Since $X \geq 0$ and $X \in \mathbb{N}$, we have

$$X = \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} 1(X \geq k) = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} 1(X > k)$$

Taking expectations, we obtain

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[X] &= \mathbb{E} \left[\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} 1(X \geq k) \right] &= \mathbb{E} \left[\sum_{k=0}^{\infty} 1(X > k) \right] \\ &= \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{E}[1(X \geq k)] &= \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{E}[1(X > k)] \\ &= \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(X \geq k) &= \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(X > k) \end{aligned}$$

■

Lecture $n + 1$ – 09/02/26

We present another proof of the inclusion-exclusion formula. First, we should establish some properties about indicator functions:

- $1(A^c) = 1 - 1(A)$;
- $1(A \cap B) = 1(A) \cdot 1(B)$;
- $1(A \cup B) = 1 - (1 - 1(A))(1 - 1(B))$.

More generally,

$$\begin{aligned} 1(A_1 \cup \dots \cup A_n) &= 1 - \prod_{i=1}^n (1 - 1(A_i)) \\ &= \sum_{i=1}^n 1(A_i) - \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < i_2 \leq n} 1(A_{i_1} \cap A_{i_2}) + \dots + (-1)^{n+1} 1(A_1 \cap \dots \cap A_n) \end{aligned}$$

Then, we can take expectations of both sides and apply $\mathbb{E}[1(A)] = \mathbb{P}(A)$ to get

$$\mathbb{P}(A_1 \cup \dots \cup A_n) = \sum_{k=1}^n (-1)^{k+1} \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \dots < i_k \leq n} \mathbb{P}(A_{i_1} \cap \dots \cap A_{i_k})$$

§4.4 Moments, variance and covariance

Definition 4.15. Let X be a random variable and $r \in \mathbb{N}$. We call $\mathbb{E}[X^r]$, as long as it is well-defined, the r^{th} moment of X .

Definition 4.16. The variance of X is given by

$$\text{Var}(X) = \mathbb{E}[(X - \mathbb{E}[X])^2]$$

Furthermore, the standard deviation of X is given by $\sqrt{\text{Var}(X)}$.

We have some properties of variance as follows:

- $\text{Var}(X) \geq 0$, since it is the expectation of a squared quantity;
- If $\text{Var}(X) = 0$, then $\mathbb{P}(X = \mathbb{E}[X]) = 1$;
- If $c \in \mathbb{R}$, then $\text{Var}(cX) = c^2 \text{Var}(X)$ and $\text{Var}(X + c) = \text{Var}(X)$.

Lemma 4.17

The variance of X is also given by

$$\text{Var}(X) = \mathbb{E}[X^2] - \mathbb{E}[X]^2$$

Proof. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Var}(X) &= \mathbb{E}[X^2 - 2X\mathbb{E}[X] + (\mathbb{E}[X])^2] \\ &= \mathbb{E}[X^2] - 2\mathbb{E}[X]\mathbb{E}[X] + (\mathbb{E}[X])^2 \\ &= \mathbb{E}[X^2] - \mathbb{E}[X]^2 \end{aligned}$$

■

Lemma 4.18

The function $\mathbb{E}[(X - c)^2]$ is minimised when $c = \mathbb{E}[X]$, and at that point is equal to $\text{Var}(X)$.

Proof. We have

$$\begin{aligned} f(c) &= \mathbb{E}[(X - c)^2] \\ &= \mathbb{E}[X^2] - 2c\mathbb{E}[X] + c^2 \\ \implies f'(c) &= -2\mathbb{E}[X] + 2c = 0 \\ \implies c &= \mathbb{E}[X] \end{aligned}$$

■

Example 4.19 ① Suppose $X \sim \text{Bin}(n, p)$. Recall $\mathbb{E}[X] = np$. We have

$$\text{Var}(X) = \mathbb{E}[X(X-1)] + \mathbb{E}[X] - \mathbb{E}[X]^2$$

Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[X(X-1)] &= \sum_{k=2}^n k(k-1) \frac{n!}{k!(n-k)!} p^k (1-p)^{n-k} \\ &= (n-1)np^2 \sum_{k=0}^{n-2} \binom{n-2}{k} p^k (1-p)^{n-2-k} \\ &= (n-1)np^2 \end{aligned}$$

so that $\text{Var}(X) = (n-1)np^2 + np - n^2p^2 = np(1-p)$.

② Suppose $X \sim \text{Poi}(\lambda)$. Recall $\mathbb{E}[X] = \lambda$. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[X(X-1)] &= \sum_{k=2}^{\infty} k(k-1) e^{-\lambda} \frac{\lambda^k}{k!} \\ &= e^{-\lambda} \lambda^2 \sum_{k=2}^{\infty} \frac{\lambda^{k-2}}{(k-2)!} = \lambda^2 \end{aligned}$$

So $\text{Var}(X) = \lambda^2 + \lambda - \lambda^2 = \lambda$.

Definition 4.20. Let X and Y be random variables. Then the *covariance* of X and Y is

$$\text{Cov}(X, Y) = \mathbb{E}[(X - \mathbb{E}[X])(Y - \mathbb{E}[Y])]$$

We have some properties:

- $\text{Cov}(X, Y) = \text{Cov}(Y, X)$;
- $\text{Cov}(X, X) = \text{Var}(X)$;
- for any $c \in \mathbb{R}$, $\text{Cov}(cX, Y) = c \text{Cov}(X, Y)$ and $\text{Cov}(X + c, Y) = \text{Cov}(X, Y)$;
- for any $c \in \mathbb{R}$, $\text{Cov}(c, X) = 0$.

Lemma 4.21

The covariance of X and Y is given by

$$\text{Cov}(X, Y) = \mathbb{E}[XY] - \mathbb{E}[X]\mathbb{E}[Y]$$

Proof. Expand. ■

Lemma 4.22

For random variables X and Y , we have

$$\text{Var}(X + Y) = \text{Var}(X) + \text{Var}(Y) + 2 \text{Cov}(X, Y)$$

Proof. We have

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Var}(X + Y) &= \mathbb{E}[(X - \mathbb{E}[X]) + (Y - \mathbb{E}[Y])]^2 \\ &= \text{Var}(X) + 2 \text{Cov}(X, Y) + \text{Var}(Y)\end{aligned}$$

■

Lemma 4.23

For $c_1, \dots, c_n$ and $d_1, \dots, d_n \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$\text{Cov}\left(\sum_{i=1}^n c_i X_i, \sum_{j=1}^n d_j Y_j\right) = \sum_{i,j=1}^n c_i d_j \text{Cov}(X_i, Y_j)$$

Corollary 4.24

We have

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Var}\left(\sum_{i=1}^n X_i\right) &= \text{Cov}\left(\sum_{i=1}^n X_i, \sum_{i=1}^n X_i\right) \\ &= \sum_{i=1}^n \text{Var}(X_i) + \sum_{i \neq j} \text{Cov}(X_i, X_j)\end{aligned}$$

Let us consider some results on independence.

Lemma 4.25

Suppose X_1, X_2 and X_3 are independent – then X_1 and X_2 are independent.

Proof. We have

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}(X_1 = x_1, X_2 = x_2) &= \sum_{x_3} \mathbb{P}(X_1 = x_1, X_2 = x_2, X_3 = x_3) \\ &= \sum_{x_3} \mathbb{P}(X_1 = x_1) \mathbb{P}(X_2 = x_2) \mathbb{P}(X_3 = x_3) \\ &= \mathbb{P}(X_1 = x_1) \mathbb{P}(X_2 = x_2)\end{aligned}$$

■

Remark. The result obviously generalises to any subset of a set of independent events being independent.

Lemma 4.26

Let X and Y be two independent random variables, and let $f, g : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}_+$. Then

$$\mathbb{E}[f(X)g(Y)] = \mathbb{E}[f(X)]\mathbb{E}[g(Y)]$$

Proof. Let the random variable $Z = (X, Y)$, so $h(Z) = f(X)g(Y)$. Then

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}[h(Z)] &= \sum_{(x,y)} h(x,y) \mathbb{P}(Z = (x,y)) \\ &= \sum_{(x,y)} f(x)g(y) \mathbb{P}(X = x, Y = y) \\ &= \sum_{(x,y)} f(x)g(y) \mathbb{P}(X = x) \mathbb{P}(Y = y) \\ &= \mathbb{E}[f(X)] \cdot \mathbb{E}[g(Y)]\end{aligned}$$

■

Proposition 4.27

If X and Y are independent, $\text{Cov}(X, Y) = 0$.

Remark. The converse is not true.

Example 4.28

Let X_1, X_2, X_3 be independent Bernoulli random variables with $p = \frac{1}{2}$. Let $Y_1 = 2X_1 - 1$, $Y_2 = 2X_2 - 1$. Also let $Z_1 = Y_1X_3$, $Z_2 = Y_2X_3$. Then $\mathbb{E}[Y_1] = \mathbb{E}[Y_2] = 0$, and $\mathbb{E}[Z_1] = \mathbb{E}[Z_2] = 0$ by independence. Then

$$\text{Cov}(Z_1, Z_2) = \mathbb{E}[Z_1 Z_2] = \mathbb{E}[Y_1 Y_2 X_3^2]$$

But we claim Z_1 and Z_2 are not independent. Observe $\mathbb{P}(Z_1 = 0, Z_2 = 0) = \mathbb{P}(X_3 = 0) = \frac{1}{2}$. But $\mathbb{P}(Z_1 = 0) = \mathbb{P}(Z_2 = 0) = \frac{1}{2}$.

§4.5 Inequalities on random variables

Proposition 4.29 (Markov's inequality)

Let X be a non-negative random variable and $a > 0$. Then

$$\mathbb{P}(X \geq a) \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}[X]}{a}$$

Proof. We have

$$\begin{aligned}X &\geq a \cdot 1(X \geq a) \\ \implies E[X] &\geq a \cdot \mathbb{P}(X \geq a)\end{aligned}$$

by taking expectations. ■

Proposition 4.30 (Chebyshev's inequality)

Let X be a random variable with $\mathbb{E}[X] < \infty$. Then, for any $a > 0$,

$$\mathbb{P}(|X - \mathbb{E}[X]| \geq a) \leq \frac{\text{Var}(X)}{a^2}$$

Proof. Observe

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(|X - \mathbb{E}[X]| \geq a) &= \mathbb{P}((X - \mathbb{E}[X])^2 \geq a^2) \\ &\leq \frac{\mathbb{E}[(X - \mathbb{E}[X])^2]}{a^2} && \text{by Markov} \\ &= \frac{\text{Var}(X)}{a^2} \end{aligned}$$

■

Proposition 4.31 (Cauchy-Schwarz)

Let X and Y be random variables, then

$$\mathbb{E}[|XY|] \leq \sqrt{\mathbb{E}[X^2] \cdot \mathbb{E}[Y^2]}$$

Proof. Assume that $\mathbb{E}[X^2]$ and $\mathbb{E}[Y^2]$ are finite, otherwise there is nothing to prove. Then, $|XY| \leq \frac{1}{2}(X^2 + Y^2)$, so, taking expectations, $\mathbb{E}[|XY|]$ is also finite. We may also assume $\mathbb{E}[X^2] > 0$, $\mathbb{E}[Y^2] > 0$. Let us also assume for the time being that $X, Y \geq 0$.

Let $t \in \mathbb{R}$ and consider $(X - tY)^2$. We have

$$\begin{aligned} 0 &\leq \mathbb{E}[(X - tY)^2] \\ &= \mathbb{E}[X^2] - 2t\mathbb{E}[XY] + t^2\mathbb{E}[Y^2] := f(t) \end{aligned}$$

Then $f'(t) = -2\mathbb{E}[XY] + 2t\mathbb{E}[Y^2]$, so $\min f(t)$ is achieved at $t^* = \frac{\mathbb{E}[XY]}{\mathbb{E}[Y^2]}$. We hence have

$$\begin{aligned} 0 &\leq \mathbb{E}[X^2] - 2\frac{\mathbb{E}[XY]^2}{\mathbb{E}[Y^2]} + \frac{\mathbb{E}[XY]^2}{\mathbb{E}[Y^2]} \\ \implies \mathbb{E}[XY]^2 &\leq \mathbb{E}[X^2] \cdot \mathbb{E}[Y^2] \end{aligned}$$

■

Remark. We could also have just put in our value for t^* from the beginning – the minimisation approach is purely to provide rationale.

Remark. When is equality achieved? We would need $f(t^*) = 0$, that is

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[(X - t^*Y)^2] &= 0 \\ \implies \mathbb{P}(X = t^*Y) &= \mathbb{P}(X - t^*Y = 0) = 1 \end{aligned}$$

so X is just a multiple of Y .

Definition 4.32 (Convexity). A function $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is called *convex* if, for any $x, y \in \mathbb{R}$ and any $t \in [0, 1]$,

$$f(tx + (1 - t)y) \leq tf(x) + (1 - t)f(y)$$

Proposition 4.33 (Jensen's inequality)

Let X be a random variable, and $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ a convex function. Then

$$\mathbb{E}[f(X)] \geq f(\mathbb{E}[X])$$

Remark. We can remember the direction of the inequality by putting $f(x) = x^2$ and using non-negativity of the variance.

Lemma 4.34

Let $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be a convex function. Then f is the supremum of all the lines lying below it. In other words, for all $m \in \mathbb{R}$, there exist $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ such that $f(m) = am + b$ and $f(x) \geq ax + b$ for all x .

Proof of lemma. Let $m \in \mathbb{R}$, and suppose $x < m < y$. Then $m = tx + (1 - t)y$ for some $t \in [0, 1]$, or, equivalently,

$$t(m - x) = (1 - t)(y - m) \quad (*)$$

By convexity, we have

$$\begin{aligned} f(m) &= f(tx + (1 - t)y) \leq tf(x) + (1 - t)f(y) \\ \implies t(f(m) - f(x)) &\leq (1 - t)(f(y) - f(m)) \\ (*) \implies \frac{f(m) - f(x)}{m - x} &\leq \frac{f(y) - f(m)}{y - m} \end{aligned}$$

Then set

$$a = \sup_{x < m} \frac{f(m) - f(x)}{m - x}$$

so that, for any $x < m < y$,

$$\frac{f(m) - f(x)}{m - x} \leq a \leq \frac{f(y) - f(m)}{y - m}$$

Hence, by rearrangement, we conclude $f(z) \geq a(z - m) + f(m)$, for any z (depending on whether z is greater than m or less than m , we use either the left or right inequality.) ■

Proof of proposition. Let $m = \mathbb{E}[X]$. By the claim, we have $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ such that $f(m) = am + b$ and $f(x) \geq ax + b$ for all x . We have

$$\begin{aligned} f(X) &\geq aX + b \\ \implies \mathbb{E}[f(X)] &\geq a\mathbb{E}[X] + b = am + b = f(m) = f(\mathbb{E}[X]) \end{aligned}$$

■

Remark. When is equality achieved?

Suppose f convex with the extra property that, for $n = \mathbb{E}[X]$, there exist $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ with $f(m) = am + b$ but $f(x) > ax + b$, note the strict inequality, for $x \neq m$. When should X satisfy $\mathbb{E}[f(X)] = f(\mathbb{E}[X])$?

Since $f(X) \geq aX + b$, we have $f(X) - (aX + b) \geq 0$. Taking expectations, we have

$$\mathbb{E}[f(X)] \geq a\mathbb{E}[X] + b = am + b = f(m) = f(\mathbb{E}[X])$$

Since we want $\mathbb{E}[f(X)] = f(\mathbb{E}[X])$, we must have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[f(X) - (aX + b)] &= 0 \\ \implies \mathbb{P}(f(X) = aX + b) &= 1 \end{aligned}$$

but then, since $f(x) > ax + b$ for $x \neq m$, we conclude $\mathbb{P}(X = m) = 1$ (if we didn't have that extra part, we'd conclude f is just a linear function).

Lecture $n + 1$

Proposition 4.35 (AM-GM inequality)

Let $x_1, \dots, x_n > 0$. Then

$$\left(\prod_{k=1}^n x_k \right)^{\frac{1}{n}} \leq \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n x_k$$

Lemma 4.36

Let f be a convex function. Then, for any $x_1, \dots, x_n \in \mathbb{R}$ we have

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n f(x_k) \geq f\left(\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n x_k\right)$$

Proof of lemma. Let X be a random variable with $\mathbb{P}(X = x_i) = \frac{1}{n}$, $i = 1, \dots, n$. Then

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n f(x_k) = \sum_x f(x) \mathbb{P}(X = x) = \mathbb{E}[f(X)]$$

so Jensen's gives

$$\mathbb{E}[f(X)] \geq f(\mathbb{E}[X]) = f\left(\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n x_k\right)$$

as required. ■

Proof of proposition. Let $f(x) = -\log x$ and suppose $x_1, \dots, x_n > 0$. Then

$$-\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n \log x_k \geq -\log \left(\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n x_k \right)$$

$$\implies \left(\prod_{k=1}^n x_k \right)^{\frac{1}{n}} \leq \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n x_k$$

as required. ■

§4.6 Joint distribution and conditional expectation

Recall if X is a discrete random variable, then the distribution of X is $(\mathbb{P}(X = x))_x$.

Definition 4.37. Let $X_1, \dots, X_n$ be discrete random variables. Their *joint distribution* is defined to be the set of values of

$$\mathbb{P}(X_1 = x_1, \dots, X_n = x_n)$$

for any $x_1, \dots, x_n$.

Remark. We can recover the distribution of any one of the variables from such a joint distribution with

$$\mathbb{P}(X_1 = x_1) = \sum_{x_2, \dots, x_n} \mathbb{P}(X_1 = x_1, X_2 = x_2, \dots, X_n = x_n)$$

In this context the distribution of the single variable is sometimes called its *marginal* distribution.

Definition 4.38. Let X and Y be discrete random variables. The *conditional distribution* of X given $Y = y$ is

$$\mathbb{P}(X = x \mid Y = y) = \frac{\mathbb{P}(X = x, Y = y)}{\mathbb{P}(Y = y)}$$

By the law of probability we of course have

$$\mathbb{P}(X = x) = \sum_y \mathbb{P}(X = x \mid Y = y) \mathbb{P}(Y = y)$$

Let X and Y be independent – what is the distribution of $X + Y$? We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(X + Y = z) &= \sum_y \mathbb{P}(X + Y = z, Y = y) \\ &= \sum_y \mathbb{P}(X = z - y, Y = y) \\ &= \sum_y \mathbb{P}(X = z - y) \mathbb{P}(Y = y) \end{aligned}$$

where the last line is by independence. This is of course a convolution.

Example

Let $X \sim \text{Poi}(\lambda)$ and $Y \sim \text{Poi}(\mu)$, with $\lambda, \mu > 0$ and $X \perp Y$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(X + Y = n) &= \sum_{k=0}^n \mathbb{P}(X = n - k) \mathbb{P}(Y = k) \\ &= e^{-\lambda} \frac{\lambda^{n-k}}{(n-k)!} \cdot e^{-\mu} \frac{\mu^k}{k!} \\ &= \frac{e^{-(\lambda+\mu)}}{n!} \sum_{k=0}^n \binom{n}{k} \lambda^{n-k} \mu^k \\ &= e^{-(\lambda+\mu)} \frac{(\lambda + \mu)^n}{n!} \end{aligned}$$

so in particular $X + Y \sim \text{Poi}(\lambda + \mu)$.

Let us derive conditional expectation for random variables. First, take $B \in \mathcal{F}$ to be an event with $\mathbb{P}(B) > 0$. We have

$$\mathbb{E}[X \mid B] = \frac{\mathbb{E}[X \cdot 1(B)]}{\mathbb{P}(B)}$$

and, if $X = 1(A)$, then

$$\mathbb{E}[1(A) \mid B] = \frac{\mathbb{E}[1(A) \cdot 1(B)]}{\mathbb{P}(B)} = \frac{\mathbb{E}[1(A \cap B)]}{\mathbb{P}(B)} = \mathbb{P}(A \mid B)$$

We can now formulate the *law of total expectation*.

Proposition 4.39 (Law of total expectation)

Let X be a random variable and (Ω_n) a partition of Ω with $\mathbb{P}(\Omega_n) > 0$ for any n . Then

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_n \mathbb{E}[X \mid \Omega_n] \mathbb{P}(\Omega_n)$$

Proof. Use indicators. We have

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \mathbb{E}[X \cdot 1(\Omega)] = \mathbb{E}\left[X \cdot \sum_n 1(\Omega_n)\right] = \sum_n \mathbb{E}[X \mid \Omega_n] \mathbb{P}(\Omega_n)$$

■

Now, we want to condition expectation not on an event but on a particular random variable. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[X \mid Y = y] &= \frac{\mathbb{E}[X \cdot 1(Y = y)]}{\mathbb{P}(Y = y)} \\ &= \sum_x x \cdot \frac{\mathbb{P}(X = x, Y = y)}{\mathbb{P}(Y = y)} \\ &= \sum_x x \cdot \mathbb{P}(X = x \mid Y = y) \end{aligned}$$

Let us now define $g(y) = \mathbb{E}[X \mid Y = y]$.

Definition 4.40. The expectation of X given Y , $\mathbb{E}[X | Y]$, is a random variable which is a function of Y . In particular,

$$\mathbb{E}[X | Y] = g(Y)$$

Example

Toss a p -coin independently n times, and let $X_i = 1(i^{\text{th}} \text{ toss is H})$. Let $Y_n = X_1 + \dots + X_n$. Let us attempt to calculate $\mathbb{E}[X_1 | Y_n]$. First, let

$$\begin{aligned} g(y) = \mathbb{E}[X_1 | Y_n = y] &= \frac{\mathbb{E}[X_1 \cdot 1(Y_n = y)]}{\mathbb{P}(Y_n = y)} \\ &= \frac{\mathbb{P}(X_1 = 1, Y_n = y)}{\mathbb{P}(Y_n = y)} \\ &= \frac{p \binom{n-1}{y-1} p^{y-1} (1-p)^{n-y}}{\binom{n}{y} p^y (1-p)^{n-y}} \\ &= \frac{y}{n} \end{aligned}$$

Hence, $\mathbb{E}[X_1 | Y_n] = \frac{Y_n}{n}$.

We have some simple and uninspiring properties:

- $\mathbb{E}[cX | Y] = c\mathbb{E}[X | Y]$;
- $\mathbb{E}[c + X | Y] = c + \mathbb{E}[X | Y]$;
- $\mathbb{E}[c | Y] = c$;
- If $X_1, \dots, X_n$ are random variables,

$$\mathbb{E} \left[\sum_{i=1}^n X_i | Y \right] = \sum_{i=1}^n \mathbb{E}[X_i | Y]$$

and some more interesting properties. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[X | Y] &= \sum_y 1(Y = y) \mathbb{E}[X | Y = y] \\ \implies \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[X | Y]] &= \sum_y \mathbb{E}[X | Y = y] \mathbb{P}(Y = y) = \mathbb{E}[X] \end{aligned}$$

Suppose now X and Y are independent random variables. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[X | Y] &= \sum_y 1(Y = y) \mathbb{E}[X | Y = y] \\ &= \sum_y 1(Y = y) \sum_x x \cdot \mathbb{P}(X = x | Y = y) \\ &= \sum_y 1(Y = y) \sum_x x \cdot \mathbb{P}(X = x) \\ &= \sum_y 1(Y = y) \mathbb{E}[X] = \mathbb{E}[X] \end{aligned}$$

Proposition 4.41

Let Y and Z be independent. Then

$$\mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[X | Y] | Z] = \mathbb{E}[X]$$

Proof. Let $g(Y) = \mathbb{E}[X | Y]$, $g(y) = \mathbb{E}[X | Y = y]$. We claim $g(Y)$ is independent of Z . Observe

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(g(Y) = w, Z = z) &= \sum_{y \in g^{-1}(\{w\})} \mathbb{P}(Y = y, Z = z) \\ &= \sum_{y \in g^{-1}(\{w\})} \mathbb{P}(Y = y) \mathbb{P}(Z = z) \\ &= \mathbb{P}(g(Y) = w) \mathbb{P}(Z = z) \end{aligned}$$

Hence, previous results give $\mathbb{E}[g(Y) | Z] = \mathbb{E}[g(Y)]$, and this is $\mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[X | Y]] = \mathbb{E}[X]$. ■

Proposition 4.42

Let X, Y be two random variables, and $h : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. Then

$$\mathbb{E}[h(Y) \cdot X | Y] = h(Y) \cdot \mathbb{E}[X | Y]$$

Proof. We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[h(Y) \cdot X | Y] &= \sum_y 1(Y = y) \mathbb{E}[h(Y) \cdot X | Y = y] \\ &= \sum_y 1(Y = y) h(y) \mathbb{E}[X | Y = y] \\ &= h(Y) \sum_y 1(Y = y) \mathbb{E}[X | Y = y] \\ &= h(Y) \mathbb{E}[X | Y] \end{aligned}$$

■

Corollary 4.43

$$\mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[X | Y] | Y] = \mathbb{E}[X | Y]$$

Example

Toss a p -coin independently n times, and let $X_i = 1$ (i^{th} toss is H). Let $Y_n = X_1 + \cdots + X_n$. What is $\mathbb{E}[X_1 | Y_n]$?

By symmetry, $\mathbb{E}[X_1 | Y_n] = \mathbb{E}[X_i | Y_n]$ for any i , $1 \leq i \leq n$. Then

$$Y_n = \mathbb{E}[Y_n | Y_n] = \mathbb{E}[X_1 + \cdots + X_n | Y_n] = n \mathbb{E}[X_1 | Y_n]$$

which was what we wanted.

§5 Random walks

Definition 5.1 (Random process). A *random process* or *stochastic process* is a sequence of random variables (X_n) .

Definition 5.2 (Random walks). A *random walk* is a random process that can be expressed as

$$X_n = x + Y_1 + \cdots + Y_n$$

where x is a number and (Y_i) are independent identically distributed (i.i.d.) random variables. We call the Y_i the *steps* of the random variable.

A *simple random walk* has

$$Y_i = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{with probability } p \\ -1 & \text{with probability } q = 1 - p \end{cases}$$

We will write

- $\mathbb{P}_x(A) = \mathbb{P}(A \mid X_0 = x)$;
- $h(x) = \mathbb{P}_x((X_n) \text{ reaches } a \text{ before } 0)$, where a is some arbitrary constant at which the game ends.

so $h(0) = 0$, $h(a) = 1$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} h(x) &= \mathbb{P}_x((X_n) \text{ hits } a \text{ bef. } 0) \\ &= \mathbb{P}_x((X_n) \text{ hits } a \text{ bef. } 0 \mid Y_1 = 1) \cdot p + \mathbb{P}_x((X_n) \text{ hits } a \text{ bef. } 0 \mid Y_1 = -1) \cdot q \\ &= p \cdot h(x+1) + q \cdot h(x-1) \end{aligned}$$

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- Case $p = q = \frac{1}{2}$, then X_n is a *simple symmetric random walk*. We have

$$\begin{aligned} h(x) &= \frac{1}{2}h(x+1) + \frac{1}{2}h(x-1) \\ \implies h(x+1) - h(x) &= h(x) - h(x-1) \\ \implies h(x) &= cx \end{aligned}$$

for some constant c . Since $h(a) = 1$, $c = \frac{1}{a}$, and hence $h(x) = \frac{x}{a}$.

- Case $p \neq q$. Let us try a solution of the form λ^x for some λ – we have

$$\begin{aligned} \lambda^x &= p\lambda^{x+1} + q\lambda^{x-1} \\ \implies \lambda &= 1, \lambda = \frac{q}{p} \end{aligned}$$

so the general solution has the form

$$h(x) = A + B \left(\frac{q}{p} \right)^x$$

which, applying boundary conditions, gives

$$h(x) = \frac{\left(\frac{q}{p}\right)^x - 1}{\left(\frac{q}{p}\right)^a - 1}$$

These results are called the *gambler's ruin estimates*.

Now let us consider a new quantity – let $T = \min\{n \geq 0 : X_n \in \{0, a\}\}$ – the first n such that X_n is either 0 or a , i.e. the duration of the game. We want to find $\mathbb{E}[T \mid X_0 = x] = \mathbb{E}_x[T] = k(x)$. We have from the law of total expectation

$$\begin{aligned} k(x) &= \mathbb{E}_x[T \mid Y_1 = 1] \cdot \mathbb{P}(Y_1 = 1) + \mathbb{E}_x[T \mid Y_1 = -1] \cdot \mathbb{P}(Y_1 = -1) \\ &= p(1 + k(x+1)) + q(1 + k(x-1)) \\ &= 1 + pk(x+1) + qk(x-1) \end{aligned}$$

with $k(0) = k(a) = 0$.

- Case $p = q = \frac{1}{2}$. Try a solution of the form Ax^2 , to get

$$\begin{aligned} Ax^2 &= 1 + pA(x+1)^2 + qA(x-1)^2 \\ \implies A &= -1 \end{aligned}$$

giving a general solution of the form $k(x) = -x^2 + Bx + C$. Applying boundary conditions, we obtain

$$k(x) = x(a-x)$$

- Case $p \neq q$. Try $k(x) = Cx$ to get

$$\begin{aligned} Cx &= 1 + pC(x+1) + qC(x-1) \\ \implies c &= \frac{1}{q-p} \end{aligned}$$

Adding this to the solution of the homogeneous equation, we obtain

$$k(x) = A + \frac{1}{q-p}x + B\left(\frac{q}{p}\right)^x$$

which, after boundary conditions, gives

$$k(x) = \frac{1}{q-p}x - \frac{a}{q-p} \cdot \frac{\left(\frac{q}{p}\right)^x - 1}{\left(\frac{q}{p}\right)^a - 1}$$

§6 Probability generating functions

Let X be a random variable with values in $\mathbb{N}$ – recall $p_r = \mathbb{P}(X = r)$ for $r \in \mathbb{N}$ constitutes the probability mass function.

Definition 6.1 (Probability generating function). The *probability generating function (PGF)* for a random variable X with values in $\mathbb{N}$ and probability masses (p_r) is

$$p(z) = \mathbb{E}[z^X] = \sum_{r=0}^{\infty} p_r z^r$$

with $|z| \leq 1$.

Remark. This is well-defined because

$$|p(z)| = \left| \sum_{r=0}^{\infty} p_r z^r \right| \leq \sum_{r=0}^{\infty} p_r |z|^r \leq \sum_{r=0}^{\infty} p_r = 1$$

so p converges absolutely for $|z| \leq 1$.

Theorem 6.2

The pgf uniquely determines the distribution of X .

Proof. Let (p_r) and (q_r) be two probability distributions with the same pgf's – for all $|z| \leq 1$, $\sum p_r z^r = \sum q_r z^r$.

Plugging in $z = 0$ gives $p_0 = q_0$. We now proceed by strong induction. Suppose $p_r = q_r$ for all $r \leq n$, so

$$\sum_{r=n+1}^{\infty} p_r z^r = \sum_{r=n+1}^{\infty} q_r z^r$$

Clearly dividing by z^{n+1} and setting $z = 0$ gives $p_{n+1} = q_{n+1}$ as required. ■

Proposition 6.3

Suppose $X_1, \dots, X_n$ are independent random variables with pgf's $q_i(z)$, and let $X = X_1 + \dots + X_n$ have pgf p . Then

$$p(z) = q_1(z) \dots q_n(z)$$

Proof. Clearly

$$p(z) = \mathbb{E}[z^{X_1 + \dots + X_n}] = \mathbb{E}[X_1] \dots \mathbb{E}[X_n] = q_1(z) \dots q_n(z)$$

by independence. ■

Example

Let us calculate some pgf's for important distributions.

- ① *Binomial*. Suppose $X \sim \text{Bin}(n, p)$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} p(z) &= \sum_{k=0}^n z^k \binom{n}{k} p^k (1-p)^{n-k} \\ &= (pz + 1 - p)^n \end{aligned}$$

- ② *Geometric*. Suppose $X \sim \text{Geo}(p)$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[z^X] &= \sum_{r=0}^{\infty} z^r (1-p)^r p \\ &= \frac{p}{1 - z(1-p)} \end{aligned}$$

- ③ *Poisson*. Suppose $X \sim \text{Poi}(\lambda)$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[z^X] &= \sum_{r=0}^{\infty} z^r e^{-\lambda} \frac{\lambda^r}{r!} \\ &= e^{\lambda(z-1)} \end{aligned}$$

Example

This fact can make calculating the pmf of sums of random variables easier. For example, suppose $X \sim \text{Bin}(n, p)$ and $Y \sim \text{Bin}(m, p)$ with $X \perp Y$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[z^{X+Y}] &= \mathbb{E}[z^X] \mathbb{E}[z^Y] = (pz + 1 - p)^n \cdot (pz + 1 - p)^m \\ &= (pz + 1 - p)^{n+m} \end{aligned}$$

from which it follows that $X + Y \sim \text{Bin}(n + m, p)$.

What about Poisson? Suppose $X \sim \text{Poi}(\lambda)$, $Y \sim \text{Poi}(\mu)$, and $X \perp Y$. Then

$$\mathbb{E}[z^{X+Y}] = e^{\lambda(z-1)} e^{\mu(z-1)} = e^{(\lambda+\mu)(z-1)}$$

from which it follows that $X + Y \sim \text{Poi}(\lambda + \mu)$.

For the following results, it will be helpful to introduce the notation

$$p(1^-) = \lim_{z \rightarrow 1^-} p(z)$$

Proposition 6.4

Let X be a discrete random variable with pgf $p(z)$, then

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = p'(1^-)$$

Proof. • Assume $\mathbb{E}[X] < \infty$, and take $0 < z < 1$. We have

$$p'(z) = \sum_{r=1}^{\infty} r p_r z^{r-1} \leq \sum_{r=1}^{\infty} r p_r = \mathbb{E}[X]$$

Hence p' is upper bounded by $\mathbb{E}[X]$, and it is clearly increasing, so the limit exists and is $\leq \mathbb{E}[X]$.

Let $\varepsilon > 0$. There exists N such that

$$\sum_{r=1}^N r p_r \geq \mathbb{E}[X] - \varepsilon$$

since this is what it means for the infinite sum to be equal to $\mathbb{E}[X]$. Furthermore,

$$\lim_{z \rightarrow 1^-} p'(z) \geq \lim_{z \rightarrow 1^-} \sum_{r=1}^N r p_r z^{r-1} = \sum_{r=1}^N r p_r \geq \mathbb{E}[X] - \varepsilon$$

• If $\mathbb{E}[X] = \infty$, then, for any $M \geq 0$, we have N such that

$$\sum_{r=1}^N r p_r \geq M$$

Then, as above,

$$\lim_{z \rightarrow 1^-} p'(z) \geq \lim_{z \rightarrow 1^-} \sum_{r=1}^N r p_r z^{r-1} = \sum_{r=1}^N r p_r \geq M$$

so the limit is infinite. ■

Proposition 6.5

Let X be a discrete random variable with pgf $p(z)$, then

$$\mathbb{E}[X(X-1)\dots(X-k+1)] = p^{(k)}(1^-)$$

Corollary 6.6

Let X be a discrete random variable with pgf $p(z)$, then

$$\text{Var}(X) = p''(1^-) + p'(1^-) - (p'(1^-))^2$$

Proposition 6.7

Let X be a discrete random variable with pgf $p(z)$, then

$$\mathbb{P}(X = n) = \frac{1}{n!} \left. \frac{d^n p}{dz^n} \right|_{z=0}$$

Remark. This is another way to see [theorem 6.2](#).

§6.1 Sum of a random number of random variables

Let $X_1, X_2, \dots$ be i.i.d. random variables and let N be an independent random variable with values in $\mathbb{N}$. Set

$$S_n = X_1 + \dots + X_n$$

that, is

$$S_n(\omega) = \sum_{i=1}^n X_i(\omega)$$

Passing to the random variable N , we obtain

$$S_N(\omega) = S_{N(\omega)}(\omega) = \sum_{i=1}^{N(\omega)} X_i(\omega)$$

Lemma 6.8

Let $q(z) = \mathbb{E}[z^N]$ be the pgf of N , and $p(z) = \mathbb{E}[z^{X_i}]$ be the pgf of X_i . Then

$$r(z) = \mathbb{E}[z^{S_N}] = q(p(z))$$

Proof 1. We have

$$\begin{aligned} r(z) &= \mathbb{E}[z^{S_N}] = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{E}[z^{S_N} \cdot 1(N = n)] \\ &= \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{E}[z^{S_n} \cdot 1(N = n)] \\ &= \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{E}[z^{X_1 + \dots + X_n} \cdot 1(N = n)] \\ &= \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{E}[z^{X_1 + \dots + X_n}] \mathbb{P}(N = n) \\ &= \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} (p(z))^n \mathbb{P}(N = n) \\ &= q(p(z)) \end{aligned}$$

■

Proof 2. We have

$$r(z) = \mathbb{E}[z^{S_N}] = \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[z^{S_N} \mid N]] = g(N)$$

where

$$g(n) = \mathbb{E}[z^{S_N} \mid N = n]$$

$$\begin{aligned} &= \mathbb{E}[z^{S_n}] \\ &= p(z)^n \end{aligned}$$

so that

$$\begin{aligned} r(z) &= \mathbb{E}[p(z)^n] \\ &= q(p(z)) \end{aligned}$$

■

Corollary 6.9

We have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[S_n] &= \mathbb{E}[N] \cdot \mathbb{E}[X_1] \\ \text{Var}(S_n) &= \mathbb{E}[N] \cdot \text{Var}(X_1) + \text{Var}(N) \cdot \mathbb{E}[X_1]^2 \end{aligned}$$

Proof. The first result follows from

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[S_n] &= r'(1-) \\ &= \lim_{z \rightarrow 1-} r'(z) \\ &= \lim_{z \rightarrow 1-} q'(p(z)) \lim_{z \rightarrow 1-} p'(z) \end{aligned}$$

Clearly $p(z)$ approaches 1 from below as z approaches 1 from below, so this is just

$$q'(1-)p'(1-) = \mathbb{E}[N] \cdot \mathbb{E}[X_1]$$

as required.

The second result is left as an exercise.

■

§7 Branching processes

Think of a branching process as a series of generations of offspring. We have $X_0 = 1$, there being one person in the first generation; then, in each generation, each individual produces k offspring independently with a fixed distribution (in particular, the distribution of X_1)

Let $Y_{k,n}$ with $k \geq 1$, $n \geq 0$ be i.i.d. random variables with the distribution of X_1 , interpreted as the number of offspring produced by the k^{th} individual in the n^{th} generation. Hence

$$X_{n+1} = \begin{cases} Y_{1,n} + \cdots + Y_{X_n,n} & X_n \geq 1 \\ 0 & X_n = 0 \end{cases}$$

Proposition 7.1

We have

$$\mathbb{E}[X_n] = \mathbb{E}[X_1]^n$$

Proof. We will proceed by induction. The base case is clear. Let us consider the conditional expectation $\mathbb{E}[X_{n+1} \mid X_n = m]$ – we have

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}[X_{n+1} \mid X_n = m] &= \mathbb{E}[Y_{1,n} + \cdots + Y_{m,n} \mid X_n = m] \\ &= \mathbb{E}[Y_{1,n} + \cdots + Y_{m,n}] && \text{(independence)} \\ &= m\mathbb{E}[X_1]\end{aligned}$$

so that $\mathbb{E}[X_{n+1} \mid X_n] = X_n\mathbb{E}[X_1]$. Hence $\mathbb{E}[X_{n+1}] = \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[X_{n+1} \mid X_n]] = \mathbb{E}[X_n\mathbb{E}[X_1]] = \mathbb{E}[X_n]\mathbb{E}[X_1]$, which completes the result by induction. ■

Proposition 7.2

Let $G(z) = \mathbb{E}[z^{X_1}]$, $G_n(z) = \mathbb{E}[z^{X_n}]$, then

$$G_{n+1}(z) = G(G_n(z))$$

Proof. Again, let us consider $\mathbb{E}[z^{X_{n+1}} \mid X_n = m]$. We have

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}[z^{X_{n+1}} \mid X_n = m] &= \mathbb{E}[z^{Y_{1,n} + \cdots + Y_{m,n}} \mid X_n = m] \\ &= \mathbb{E}[z^{Y_{1,n} + \cdots + Y_{m,n}}] \\ &= (G(z))^m\end{aligned}$$

Hence $G_{n+1}(z) = \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[z^{X_{n+1}} \mid X_n]] = \mathbb{E}[G(z)^{X_n}] = G_n(G(z))$ ■

§7.1 Extinction probability

Let $q_n = \mathbb{P}(X_n = 0)$, and $q = \mathbb{P}(X_n = 0 \text{ for some } n \geq 0)$. Letting A_n be the event that $X_n = 0$ for some n , we can see $q = \mathbb{P}(\cup A_n)$, and $A_n \subseteq A_{n+1}$, so the A_n form an increasing sequence and we get

$$\mathbb{P}(A_n) \rightarrow \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup A_n\right)$$

by [proposition 1.8](#) (continuity of probability measures).

Lemma 7.3

Let $G(z) = \mathbb{E}[z^{X_1}]$, then $q_{n+1} = G(q_n)$ and $q = G(q)$.

Proof 1. We have

$$\begin{aligned}q_{n+1} &= \mathbb{P}(X_{n+1} = 0) \\ &= G_{n+1}(0) \\ &= G(G_n(0)) \\ &= G(q_n)\end{aligned}$$

Then, since G is continuous and $q_n \rightarrow q$, we can simply take the limit on both sides to get $q = G(q)$ as required. ■

Proof 2. We will condition q_{n+1} on the number of individuals in the first generation, i.e. X_1 . Supposing $X_1 = m$, let $X_n^{(1)}, \dots, X_n^{(m)}$ be i.i.d. branching processes with the same distribution as the original one. Hence

$$X_{n+1} = X_n^{(1)} + \dots + X_n^{(m)}$$

So

$$\begin{aligned} q_{n+1} &= \mathbb{P}(X_{n+1} = 0) \\ &= \sum_m \mathbb{P}(X_{n+1} = 0 \mid X_1 = m) \mathbb{P}(X_1 = m) \\ &= \sum_m \mathbb{P}(X_n^{(1)} + \dots + X_n^{(m)} = 0 \mid X_1 = m) \mathbb{P}(X_1 = m) \\ &= \sum_m \left(\mathbb{P}(X_n^{(1)} = 0) \right)^m \mathbb{P}(X_1 = m) \\ &= \sum_m q_n^m \mathbb{P}(X_1 = m) \\ &= G(q_n) \end{aligned}$$

Once again, we take the limit on both sides. ■

Lecture 14 – 23/02/26

Recalling [proposition 7.1](#), we have that

- if $\mathbb{E}[X_1] < 1$, $\mathbb{E}[X_n] \rightarrow 0$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$, so we expect $q = 1$;
- if $\mathbb{E}[X_1] > 1$, $\mathbb{E}[X_n] \rightarrow \infty$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$, so we expect $q < 1$;
- if $\mathbb{E}[X_1] = 1$, then $\mathbb{E}[X_n] = 1$ for all n . But it is not clear what q will be. Let us focus on this last case.

We can also interpret these results in the context of a graph of G . We know that the graph of G will intersect x at $x = 1$, and we could either have another intersection in the range $0 \leq x < 1$, or no intersections.

- *There is another intersection.* Then iterating G starting from $G(0)$ will lead us to the other intersection. Furthermore, the gradient of G at 1, $G(1-) = \mathbb{E}[X_1]$ must be greater than 1 for there to be such an intersection, as we expect;
- *There is not another intersection.* Then iterating G will take us all the way to 1, and the gradient of G at 1, $G(1-) = \mathbb{E}[X_1]$ must be less than or equal to 1 for there not to be any further intersections. We conclude that $q = 1$ in the case $\mathbb{E}[X_1] = 1$.

Proposition 7.4

Assume $P(X_1 = 1) < 1$. The extinction probability q is the minimal non-negative solution to $G(x) = x$. Furthermore, $q < 1$ if and only if $\mathbb{E}[X_1] > 1$.

Proof. We know $q = G(q)$. Let t be the smallest minimal solution of $x = G(x)$. We will show by induction that, for any n , $q_n \leq t$, and then take limits to establish $q \leq t \implies q = t$.

For the base case, $0 = q_0 \leq t$. Suppose $q_n \leq t$, then

$$q_{n+1} = G(q_n) \leq G(t) = t$$

since G is increasing.

Now, we show $q < 1$ if and only if $\mathbb{E}[X_1] > 1$. Suppose for now $g_0 + g_1 = \mathbb{P}(X_1) \leq 1 < 1$.

Let $H(z) = G(z) - z = \sum_{r=0}^{\infty} g_r z^r - z$, so $H(1) = 0$. First, we show that H can have at most one root in $[0, 1)$. Observe

$$H''(z) = \sum_{r=0}^{\infty} r(r-1)g_r z^{r-1} > 0$$

in $(0, 1)$, because $g_0 + g_1 < 1$, so there must be some later r with a positive value of g_r , making the sum strictly larger than zero. Hence $H'(z)$ is strictly increasing, and hence can have at most one more root other than 1 – otherwise, we would have a point c with $H'(c) = 0$ by Rolle's theorem.

We now split into two cases.

- H has no root other than 1, so $q = 1$. Then $H'(1-) = G'(1-) - 1 = \mathbb{E}[X_1] - 1$. Furthermore, $H(0) = G(0) = g_0 \geq 0$ while $H(1) = 0$, so $H(z) \geq 0$ for all $z \in [0, 1]$. Now

$$H'(1-) = \lim_{z \rightarrow 1-} \frac{H(z) - H(0)}{z - 1} \leq 0$$

since the numerator is $H(z) - 0 \geq 0$ while the denominator is $z - 1 \leq 0$. Hence $H'(1-) \leq 0 \implies \mathbb{E}[X_1] \leq 1$, as required.

- H has one more root r , so r is the extinction probability. We hence have $H(r) = 0$ and $H(1) = 0$ with $r < 1$, so we have $z \in (r, 1)$ with $H'(z) = 0$ by Rolle. Hence $\mathbb{E}[X_1] - 1 = H'(-1) > H'(z) = 0$, so $\mathbb{E}[X_1] > 1$ as required.

On the other hand, if $\mathbb{P}(X_1 \leq 1) = 1$, then $\mathbb{E}[X_1] = g_1$, so

$$\begin{aligned} G(z) &= g_0 + g_1 z \\ &= 1 - \mathbb{E}[X_1] + \mathbb{E}[X_1]z \end{aligned}$$

Then, if $G(z) = z$, we have $(1 - \mathbb{E}[X_1])z = 1 - \mathbb{E}[X_1]$ and, since $\mathbb{E}[X_1] = g_1 < 1$, $1 - \mathbb{E}[X_1] \neq 0$ so $z = 1$. ■

§8 Continuous random variables

Recall [definition 4.2](#), that

Definition. Given a probability space $(\Omega, \mathcal{F}, \mathbb{P})$, a *random variable* is a function

$$X : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$$

satisfying

$$\{\omega \in \Omega : X(\omega) \leq x\} \in \mathcal{F}$$

for any x .

and [definition 4.4](#), that

Definition. Suppose X is a random variable. The *probability distribution function* of X is given by

$$F_X(x) : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow [0, 1]$$

$$x \mapsto \mathbb{P}(\{\omega \in \Omega : X(\omega) \leq x\}) = \mathbb{P}(X \leq x)$$

When dealing with discrete random variables, it was possible to only consider $\mathbb{P}(X = x)$ for some x . But now, we will have to work in more generality.

Let us observe some important properties.

- ① if $x \leq y$, then $F(x) \leq F(y)$;
- ② for any $a < b$,

$$\mathbb{P}(a < X \leq b) = F(b) - F(a)$$

Proof.

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(a < X \leq b) &= \mathbb{P}(X \leq b, X > a) \\ &= \mathbb{P}(X \leq b) - \mathbb{P}(X \leq b, X \leq a) \\ &= F(b) - F(a) \end{aligned}$$

■

Lecture 15 – 25/02/26

Proposition 8.1

A probability distribution function F is right continuous, and always has left limits satisfying

$$\lim_{y \rightarrow x^-} F(y) \leq F(x)$$

Proof. Let (x_n) be a decreasing sequence satisfying $x_n \rightarrow x$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$. We want to show $F(x_n) \rightarrow F(x)$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$.

Let $A_n = \{x < X \leq x_n\}$, so $\mathbb{P}(A_n) = F(x_n) - F(x)$ by the previous. Furthermore, $A_{n+1} \subseteq A_n$ – the sequence is decreasing – so $\mathbb{P}(A_n) \rightarrow \mathbb{P}(\bigcap_n A_n)$ by continuity of probability measures. But $\mathbb{P}(\bigcap_n A_n) = 0$, so $\mathbb{P}(A_n) \rightarrow 0$. Hence $\mathbb{P}(A_n) = F(x_n) - F(x) \rightarrow 0$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$.

Since F is increasing (and bounded), left limits always exist. That $\lim_{y \rightarrow x^-} F(y) \leq F(x)$ follows again from the fact F is increasing. ■

- ③ $F(x-) = \lim_{y \rightarrow x^-} F(y) = \mathbb{P}(X < x)$.

Proof. Clearly $F(x-) = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} F(x - \frac{1}{n})$. Define $B_n = \{X \leq x - \frac{1}{n}\}$, so $B_n \subseteq B_{n+1}$. Then

$$\mathbb{P}(B_n) \rightarrow \mathbb{P}\left(\bigcup_n B_n\right) = \mathbb{P}(X < x)$$

since $\bigcup_n B_n = \{X < x\}$. ■

$$\textcircled{4} \lim_{x \rightarrow \infty} F(x) = 1 \text{ and } \lim_{x \rightarrow -\infty} F(x) = 0.$$

Definition 8.2 (Continuous random variables). A random variable X is called *continuous* if its probability distribution F is a continuous function.

Some important properties equivalent to continuity include (fixing $x \in \mathbb{R}$):

- $F(x-) = F(x)$;
- $\mathbb{P}(X < x) = \mathbb{P}(X \leq x)$;
- $\mathbb{P}(X = x) = 0$.

From now on we will consider only continuous random variables satisfying additionally that F is differentiable.

Definition 8.3 (Probability density functions). The *probability density function* of a random variable X is $f(x) = F'(x)$, where F is its probability distribution.

Let us now consider some important properties of pdf's:

- $f \geq 0$;
- $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x) dx = 1$;

Proposition 8.4

For every $A \subseteq \mathbb{R}$,

$$\mathbb{P}(X \in A) = \int_A f(x) dx$$

Remark. This is a generalisation of the semi-obvious fact that

$$F(x) = \int_{-\infty}^x f(y) dy$$

What is the intuitive meaning of the probability density function? For a small Δx ,

$$\mathbb{P}(x < X \leq x + \Delta x) = \int_x^{x+\Delta x} f(y) dy \approx f(x)\Delta x$$

so we can think of $f(x)$ as being proportional to the probability that X is close to x .

Let us consider some important examples of continuous probability distributions.

① *Uniform distribution* on $[a, b]$, $a < b$. We have

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} \frac{1}{b-a} & x \in [a, b] \\ 0 & \text{o/w} \end{cases}$$

$f \geq 0$ and $\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x) dx = 1$, so f is indeed a pdf. Let X be a random variable with density f , denoted $X \sim [a, b]$. Then, for $x \in [a, b]$,

$$\mathbb{P}(X \leq x) = \int_{-\infty}^x f(y) dy = \frac{x-a}{b-a}$$

Also, if $x > b$, $\mathbb{P}(X \leq x) = 1$, and if $x < a$, $\mathbb{P}(X \leq x) = 0$. A special case is the *standard uniform distribution* $X \sim U(0, 1)$

② *Exponential distribution.* Let $\lambda > 0$, $f(x) = \lambda e^{-\lambda x}$, $x > 0$. Then

$$\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x) dx = \int_0^{\infty} \lambda e^{-\lambda x} dx = 1$$

so f is a density. letting X have density f , we write $X \sim \text{Exp}(\lambda)$. We have

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}(X \leq x) &= \int_0^x f(y) dy = 1 - e^{-\lambda x} \\ \mathbb{P}(X \geq x) &= e^{-\lambda x}\end{aligned}$$

Let $T \sim \text{Exp}(\lambda)$, $n \in \mathbb{N}$, $T_n = \lfloor nT \rfloor$. What is the distribution of T_n ?

Let $k \in \mathbb{N}$, and let us try to evaluate $\mathbb{P}(T_n \geq k) = \mathbb{P}(nT \geq k) = \mathbb{P}(T \geq \frac{k}{n}) = e^{-\lambda \frac{k}{n}} = \left(e^{-\frac{\lambda}{n}}\right)^k$. So T_n has the geometric distribution with success parameter $p = 1 - e^{-\frac{\lambda}{n}} \approx \frac{\lambda}{n}$ for n large. In particular,

$$\frac{T_n}{n} \rightarrow T$$

as $n \rightarrow \infty$ – we can obtain the exponential random variable as a scaled limit of geometrics.

The exponential distribution has a cool property! Let $T \sim \text{Exp}(\lambda)$, and let $t, s \in \mathbb{R}^+$. Then

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}(T \geq s+t \mid T \geq s) &= \frac{\mathbb{P}(T \geq s+t \mid T \geq s)}{\mathbb{P}(T \geq s)} \\ &= \frac{e^{-\lambda(s+t)}}{e^{-\lambda s}} = e^{-\lambda t}\end{aligned}$$

so $\mathbb{P}(T \geq s+t \mid T \geq s) = \mathbb{P}(T \geq t)$. This is called the *memoryless* property (the geometric distribution also has it).

Proposition 8.5

Let T be a positive random variable which is not identically zero or infinity. Then T has the exponential distribution if and only if T has the memoryless property.

Proof. Suppose T has the memoryless property. Set $g(t) = \mathbb{P}(T \geq t)$, so

$$g(t+s) = g(t)g(s)$$

Therefore, $g(mt) = g(t)^m$ for any $t > 0$, $m \in \mathbb{N}$. Putting $t = 1$, we have $g(m) = g(1)^m$, and we will define $\lambda = -\log \mathbb{P}(T \geq 1)$ such that $g(1) = \mathbb{P}(T \geq 1) = e^{-\lambda}$. Hence $g(m) = e^{-\lambda m}$ for all $m \in \mathbb{N}$, and, for $m, n \in \mathbb{N}$, $\left(g\left(\frac{m}{n}\right)\right)^n = g(m)$, so $g(q) = e^{-\lambda q}$ for rationals q . How do we extend this to the reals?

Let $t > 0$, and let $r, s \in \mathbb{Q}^+$ such that $s < t < r$ and $|s - r| \leq \varepsilon$, which can be done by density of the rationals. Then

$$\underbrace{g(r)}_{e^{-\lambda r}} \leq g(t) \leq \underbrace{g(s)}_{e^{-\lambda s}}$$

Taking $\varepsilon \rightarrow 0$, we get $g(t) = e^{-\lambda t}$ as required. ■